Research And Data As Tools In Advocates' Decision-Making: A Focus On China & Southeast Asia

November 2024

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Background

In January 2024, Faunalytics released Phase I of the "Research And Data As Tools In Advocates' Decision-Making" project (Faunalytics, 2024), which sought to understand how the animal advocacy movement utilizes data in order to improve the production, funding, and use of research to help animals. That report, which was based on interviews with researchers from across the world, identified that advocates in the Global South had distinctive perspectives on the use of research, noting in particular that evidence gaps on regional trends hindered their ability to use research effectively.

This study—Phase II of the same project—takes a deeper dive into research and data use among animal advocates in the Global South, specifically looking at China and Southeast Asia, a region of particular importance due to its large farmed animal population and relative neglectedness in the advocacy community (Founders Pledge, 2020).

With the aim of enhancing our understanding of how animal advocacy organizations in these regions engage with research and data, we conducted small focus group discussions with leaders of animal advocacy organizations across the region. During the analysis phase, we build on the knowledge translation framework from Phase I (which primarily focused on research utilization post-production), expanding to the more expansive framework of research engagement**,** which looks at stakeholders' interaction with research before, during, and after its production.

This report analyzes three aspects of research use: the five ways research is used, the four barriers and enablers of research use, and an overview of the entire research engagement process. It also seeks to understand the differences in how Asian advocates use research, as compared to advocates in the Global North. By understanding these critical levers of data usage, advocates and funders—both within Asia and globally—can support animal advocates in China and Southeast Asia in their efforts to protect animals in the region.

Key Findings

1. **Research is used both externally (to understand, influence, and support external stakeholders) and internally (to inform internal organizational and program decisions) and can sometimes lead to a significant shift in strategy.** In advocates' external engagement, research is a key part of campaigns working with corporate stakeholders, policymakers, producers, or other members of the advocacy movement. For internal use cases, we found that research is used to prioritize and improve activities within an organization, to test the effectiveness or viability of interventions, or even to

reconsider an organization's broader strategy or advocacy approach—one advocate described how research encouraged them to shift from vegan street advocacy to corporate campaigns.

2. **Barriers to research use include localization, credibility, accessibility, and usability. Localization**—adapting research to be relevant to Asian contexts in both content and format—is a key enabler. Localized research makes it easier for advocates to design locally-relevant interventions, generate persuasive arguments for local stakeholders, and prioritize appropriate strategies. **Credibility** is also essential, as trustworthy findings from known sources reinforce an organization's legitimacy by enhancing its evidence-based image. Some stakeholders found certain research more credible due to contextual factors, such as a preference for specific universities or partners, or viewing the work of organizations like the World Bank as particularly credible due to its role as a major funder. **Accessibility** is also an important consideration, and ensuring that research is free-to-access and consolidated in easily accessible locations enhances an organization's ability to find and effectively use existing research. Finally, to ensure **usability**, the format, content and timing are also key—research should be delivered in stakeholder-appropriate formats, with relevant content at an appropriate level of detail, and at a time when it can be most useful.

3. **The research engagement process has four stages: Plan, Produce, Apply, and Evaluate.** In the Plan stage, organizations set goals, allocate resources, and identify the stakeholders they need to engage. The Produce stage involves designing research, collecting data, and analyzing results. The Apply stage focuses on communicating and sharing findings in practical work. The Evaluate stage focuses on refining processes through feedback and reflection for continuous improvement.

4. **Many Asian advocates localize and produce their own research, sometimes through partnerships.** Nearly all advocates in our study were involved in some form of research production, often in collaboration with local university researchers or other research organizations. This is likely to be because of the lack of local studies and data, which compels advocates to conduct their own research to fill knowledge gaps. With the small size of the Asian advocacy movement, this means advocates often have to wear both advocacy and research hats.

5. **Advocates frequently engage stakeholders such as farmers and corporations throughout the different stages of research to increase the use and usefulness of research efforts.** Advocates gave many examples of how they engaged external stakeholders in order to effectively produce research. For example, collaborating with farmers and local officials during the planning phase facilitated smoother data collection in a rural agricultural research project, incorporating feedback from local researchers and partners from different disciplines allowed for improved analysis, and engaging key

corporate stakeholders when building advocacy cases enabled advocates to tailor research content and dissemination formats to build a more persuasive case.

6. **Data consolidation, sharing, and tools may be promising ways to improve research access, use, and data collection efficiency.** Many advocates highlighted the need for more consolidated data and increased sharing among advocates to facilitate access to a broader range of resources, avoid duplicating efforts, and save time spent searching for materials. Current challenges include advocates spending excessive time searching across multiple platforms, discomfort with data sharing, and difficulty accessing materials used by other advocates.

7. **The most widely used scientific fields are welfare science and environmental research, but advocates also cite behavioral research, meta-level studies on advocacy approaches, and interdisciplinary crossovers as key subjects for further exploration.** Many advocates want more research targeted specifically on Asian consumer behavior, meta-level studies (such as identifying the most impactful advocacy tactics or interventions in Asia), and intersectional research that explores various factors like religion, social change, and dietary change. Research into animal welfare, environmental sustainability, and the effects of animal products on human health are the most commonly used topics, but are perceived as less neglected, potentially due to their universal applicability.

Recommendations

For Animal Advocacy Organizations:

- **For organizations in Asia, explore alternative funding and human resources.** Small organizations may lack internal resources, but could tap into university research budgets by partnering with university researchers and applying for targeted funding, or leverage international talent through platforms like Vegan Thesis.

- **For organizations in Asia, explore ways to leverage technology for improved data collection and consolidation**. Increasingly accessible and powerful AI systems may expand the possibilities for advocates to create independent data monitoring and collection systems that streamline data management and analysis. Advocates can leverage support from groups like Vegan Hacktivists, and draw inspiration from recent examples including the Global Fishing Watch.

- **For organizations in Asia, consider underlooked ways where research can improve your impact.** While advocates commonly use research for purposes like influencing external stakeholders, informing internal strategy, and designing new interventions, many could likely benefit from exploring additional use cases. Potentially

overlooked areas might include generating training materials for staff and volunteers, developing research-based decision-making tools, or using data to estimate the effectiveness of their work. Expanding how research is used (or *not* used) in your organization could significantly enhance advocacy efforts.

- **For organizations in the Global North, actively foster a research-sharing culture.** Advocates from smaller Asian organizations reported experiencing "imposter syndrome" and hesitated to share their research to the global community (e.g. with the FAST community). Strategies to improve this could include supporting smaller Asian organizations to share research online or at events, organizing research exchange workshops, and active encouragement of research that discusses regional issues in developing nations.

- **For all organizations, enhance research-sharing infrastructure with a focus on localized customization.** Regional and global organizations can better curate and adapt resources like online tools, advocacy briefs, and toolkits to meet specific regional needs (e.g., case studies, low-resource applications, data segmented by country or stakeholder). This research-sharing infrastructure should also enable smaller organizations to contribute insights on a common platform, enhancing both local and global knowledge exchange.

  In the coming years, Faunalytics plans to expand its role as a central database hub, adding tools to help advocates understand the public's opinion of farming practices, the impact of undercover investigations, and more. We aim to create resources that can be customized to any region, allowing advocates from across the world to use the data that's most relevant to them.

For Researchers (Including Advocate Researchers):

- **Engage your target research users when planning, producing, and evaluating research.** Researchers should prioritize engaging local advocates early in the process to understand what kinds of research they need, and consider involving large-scale stakeholders, such as policymakers or corporate leaders, to ensure the research is relevant and useful. For example, consulting with policy campaigners or policymakers when seeking to influence welfare policy can help researchers tailor their research to be more useful by aligning the format, content, or data source with policymakers' preferences, thereby increasing its potential impact.

- **Conduct targeted, locally relevant research and consider replicating global research on a regional level.** Researchers should focus on subjects important to local contexts, such as welfare science and the intersections of agriculture, environment, and human health, while also addressing neglected but in-demand topics like Asian consumer behavior and effective advocacy tactics in Asia. Researchers should also consider conducting localized replications of influential international studies, such as the

EU "smart protein" study, which are likely to yield relevant and usable findings. Conducting broader landscape studies could further provide comprehensive insights that benefit both international and local advocates. Read Faunalytics' replication guide for inspiration.

- **Adapt research reports into other formats—such as training materials, briefs, or videos—to improve accessibility for advocates and other stakeholders.** In addition to translating existing and future research outputs, researchers should consider creating tailored adaptations for different stakeholder groups in various countries. This could include training materials for advocates, briefs for policymakers, or video overviews for the general public. Collaborating with local advocates and community builders can enhance this process, ensuring that materials are accessible and relevant across diverse contexts. These could be shared in a repository or shared database.

- **Conduct a movement-level data audit to strategically set a research agenda.** Assessing the data currently held by each organization is necessary to understand existing resources and identify key gaps. Based on this audit, prioritize coordinated data collection, areas where existing evidence can be synthesized and reviewed, and new studies targeting the most critical gaps, ensuring that efforts are concentrated on areas with the highest potential impact. This kind of systematic approach has the potential to streamline research efforts across the movement and improving the quality of research available can allow the proliferation of evidence-driven strategies in the region.

For Funders:

- **Fund initiatives that address local knowledge gaps.** Direct funding towards areas where Asian advocates face significant knowledge gaps that limit their ability to impact important, neglected practices affecting large populations of farmed animals. This may also involve increasing support for local research efforts and allocating resources for the localization and translation of research to ensure that research remains relevant and accessible in these key areas.

- **Fund the *entire* research pipeline, including research dissemination, engagement, and evaluation.** In order to prioritize impactful research, initiatives should consider the key stages of the research process. This might involve including research engagement as a funding criterion or allocating resources for research planning, production, dissemination, engagement, and evaluation, recognizing that the impact of research can occur at various stages.

- **Invest in infrastructure to improve research access and distribution.** Ensure that Asian researchers and advocates have the necessary infrastructure to access, share, review, and enhance the research used in the animal advocacy movement. This could include creating regional data hubs to consolidate and share research data among

organizations, developing user-friendly tools to integrate research into advocacy efforts, or establishing accessible sharing platforms for advocates across the movement.

Applying These Findings

We understand that reports like this have a lot of information to consider and that acting on research can be challenging. Faunalytics is happy to offer pro bono support to advocates and nonprofit organizations who would like guidance applying these findings to their own work. Please visit our virtual Office Hours or contact us for support.

Behind The Project

Research Team

The project's lead authors were Jah Ying Chung (Good Growth) and Jack Stennett (Good Growth). Dr. Jo Anderson (Faunalytics), Dr. Peter John Chen (University of Sydney), and Dr. Andie Thompkins (Faunalytics, Mercy for Animals) reviewed and oversaw the work.

Acknowledgements

We would like to thank several advocates who provided valuable input about this research throughout the process. We would like to thank our funders for their generous support of this research.

Research Terminology

At Faunalytics, we strive to make research accessible to everyone. We avoid jargon and technical terminology as much as possible in our reports. If you do encounter an unfamiliar term or phrase, check out the Faunalytics Glossary for user-friendly definitions and examples.

Research Ethics Statement

As with all of Faunalytics' original research, this study was conducted according to the standards outlined in our Research Ethics and Data Handling Policy.

Method

This section provides an overview of the research questions, design, sampling, data collection and analysis of this study. For more detailed information, see the *Supplementary Materials* section.

This is a qualitative research study that aims to explore how animal advocacy organizations working in China and Southeast Asia engage with research and data to achieve their goals. Building upon the first phase (Phase I) of research (Faunalytics, 2024), this study emphasizes the role of stakeholder engagement in research, and allows us to expand upon the more linear "knowledge translation" framework (Estabrooks et al, 2006) to integrate stakeholder and advocate involvement before and during research production (Davies et al, 2015). We will consider more recent models of research engagement, including participatory, relational, community-based and systems-based approaches (Chung, 2024) to explore these issues. Research was conducted through small focus group discussions with representatives of animal protection organizations working in the region.

This study was a collaboration between Faunalytics, Good Growth and the University of Sydney. The design of this study was supported by Dr. Jo Anderson from Faunalytics and Dr. Peter Chen from the University of Sydney, who contributed to the ethics approval process, research planning, the interview guide, and the sampling approach. Only the research team at Good Growth was involved in participant selection or participation, and only they have access to interview transcripts. This was done to protect participants' confidentiality and their ability to speak freely about research in animal advocacy.

The discussion guide was developed to understand different research use cases with various stakeholders, explore preferred types and formats of data, map research engagement processes, and identify enablers, barriers, and solutions.

The central research questions were:

1. What are the different use cases of research in Asian animal advocacy?
2. How does research engagement vary by use case and/or stakeholder type (i.e. the target audience that the advocate group is trying to influence/work with)?
3. How might we increase the impact of research for animal advocates?

Sample Frame

The initial longlist of 52 organizations working in Greater China (including mainland China and Hong Kong/Macau/Taiwan) and/or Southeast Asia was compiled from existing datasets by

Faunalytics and Good Growth. We selected organizations based on two criteria, the primary stakeholders they target and the countries in which they worked.

We contacted leaders from these organizations to participate in focus group discussions. A screening questionnaire confirmed participants' leadership roles and appropriate regional focus, as well as the stakeholders they worked with, ensuring coverage of major stakeholders such as policy and corporate institutions, local institutions (e.g., schools, hospitals, food producers), community members, and individuals/the general public.

From the longlist of 52 organizations, we sent out 37 participation requests, receiving 17 responses. Representatives from 16 organizations participated in the final focus groups—a 43% response rate.

Participants

Organizations were identified as working with various stakeholder types, with most engaging multiple groups, including policy and corporate institutions, local institutions, advocates, other social movements, individuals/the general public, as well as some who worked with animals directly. They also specified the countries and regions they operated in. See details in the table below.

Table 1: Overview of Participant Organizations

Category	Number of Organizations (n)
Stakeholder Focus	
General public/consumers	13
Corporations/businesses	12
Policymakers/legal or political figures	9
Other animal advocacy groups	9
Other social movements (e.g., climate activists)	5
Animals directly	2
Organizations' Stakeholder Scope	
Worked across 5 stakeholder categories	3
Worked across 4 stakeholder categories	4
Worked across 3 stakeholder categories	3
Worked across 2 stakeholder categories	4
Worked within a single stakeholder category	1
Regions/Countries of Operation	

Mainland China	7
Indonesia	5
Philippines	5
Southeast Asia (regional)	4
Vietnam	5
Malaysia	4
Taiwan	4
Thailand	3
Singapore	3
Hong Kong SAR	3
Macau SAR	1

Analysis Method

Interview transcriptions and notes were analyzed using an iterative, inductive thematic coding approach. Thematic coding involved a distinct set of codes for each research question. We conducted analysis based on the knowledge framework laid out in the Results section.

See the Supplementary Materials section for more details on the analysis process.

Knowledge Framework

We reviewed a range of literature including the Phase I report, reports from other animal advocacy organizations (e.g. Animal Charity Evaluators), and broader disciplines (based on a multidisciplinary review by one of this report's authors; Chung, 2024) to inform the design of this study. We also incorporated ideas from this literature review into this study's design (e.g. focus group interview guide) and analysis.

Our review covered three main areas, which will be discussed in this section:

1. **Use cases:** Specific instances or ways in which research or data is applied or utilized. For example, research can be used to inform strategy, or to directly influence external stakeholders.
2. **Barriers, and enablers:** Features of research, such as topic, format, methodology, or style, and how these attributes either obstruct or support the effective use of research within these use cases.

3. **Research engagement process:** The procedures and stakeholders involved in the engagement and implementation of research activities, including the planning, production, application, and evaluation of research.

Use Cases

While research engagement in animal advocacy remains relatively underexplored, some studies have examined how research is used in real-life contexts, which we will refer to as *use cases*. Phase I of this study identified a variety of research use cases in global animal advocacy. These are framed as:

- **Establishing legitimacy**: Evidence helps organizations establish legitimacy with individuals and institutions they aim to influence.
- **Supporting internal decision-making**: Research informs internal decisions on foundational priorities.
- **Building partnerships and alliances**: Research processes and outputs help build partnerships across animal advocacy organizations and related movements.
- **Catalyzing action**: Evidence is used to drive action by individuals and institutions.
- **Identifying and Communicating Issues:** Evidence is used to improve the communication of problems and solutions in animal welfare and wellbeing, contributing to broader communication efforts, including communication to consumers about dietary choices.

Other organizations such as Animal Charity Evaluators (ACE) have discussed the internal use of research by organizations in strategic planning, intervention design, evaluating impact, and exploring emerging issues in the field (ACE, 2023). On a movement level, they have examined how research influences how advocates prioritize interventions and actions, and enables them to identify effective strategies for developing the field of animal advocacy as a whole (ACE, 2021).

For this study, we have synthesized these findings and established two categories of use cases: internal uses (at the organizational and program level) and external uses (understanding, influencing, and supporting stakeholders).

Barriers And Enablers

Previous studies have also identified barriers that stop research from being used or engaged with, and enablers—traits that allow it to be used or engaged with more effectively.

One feature Animal Charity Evaluators (ACE) have highlighted is research methodology. Animal Charity Evaluators (ACE) emphasizes the importance of choosing the right methods to improve the quality and impact of studies. By understanding and strategically using different research approaches—like quantitative surveys, qualitative interviews, experiments, case studies, and

reviews of multiple studies (meta-analysis)—researchers can design better studies that match their specific goals. This ensures that the research is more relevant, accurate, and useful for the intended purpose (ACE, 2023).

Phase I of this report identified several additional features that users may prefer. This includes a variety of formats (such as reports, academic articles, evidence summaries, research reviews), methodologies or approaches (evaluations), and topics (such as animal well-being and behavioral change), depending on their specific needs. The report specifically highlighted that real-world applied research, studies on the influence of social movements, assessments of the effectiveness of behavioral nudges, and research focused on animal well-being for particular species and contexts were particularly desirable. Phase I also observed that peer-reviewed academic research is often regarded as the "gold standard" for credibility, showing that it was the most effective in building legitimacy—a key objective in Phase I. However, it also acknowledged that peer-reviewed research might not be the best fit for all purposes.

Academic research has also addressed the barriers and enablers to effective research engagement: Hemsley-Brown (2004) points out that limited accessibility and relevance, trust and credibility issues, and the disconnect between researchers and users can negatively affect engagement with research. Phase I echoed these concerns, noting that while vegan research organizations excel in producing accessible and relevant content, they may face trust issues due to perceived conflicts of interest. Conversely, enablers such as better support and training, collaboration, effective dissemination, robust networks, and strong leadership can enhance research utilization. Hemsley-Brown also emphasizes that building communication networks, strengthening ties between researchers and practitioners, and increasing practitioner involvement are key factors for boosting research impact.

In this study, we adopted a framework similar to that used in Phase I to identify research features—such as formats, methodologies, and topics—that function as barriers or enablers. This framework of barriers and enablers helps us determine the characteristics that make research more likely to be used and valued by advocates.

Research Engagement Process

Our study of the academic literature also prompted us to expand the scope of this study from research translation (in Phase I) to research engagement. Phase I of this study applied the framework of research translation, with a primary focus on the process of how research is used after it is produced. In this Phase II study, we expand our scope to the framework of research engagement—seeing advocate engagement with research as a process where advocates play a role at multiple stages of the research process—from planning and designing a study, to applying its findings, to evaluating its impact.

The idea of having stakeholders involved at different stages of the research process has been mentioned by organizations in the animal advocacy space, as well as academics such as Polk (2015), and Fransman (2018).

Animal-focused Effective Altruism (EA) organizations, such as Animal Charity Evaluators and Charity Entrepreneurship, mention several stages of research engagement in animal advocacy. For example, Sarek (2019) from Charity Entrepreneurship emphasizes the importance of actively involving stakeholders in the creation and prioritization of research questions. She describes how the process of research engagement can be strengthened by gathering input from decision-makers, evaluating the significance of various research questions, and selecting the most impactful ones based on these assessments.

Organizations also explore how groups can be supported through different stages of research engagement, such as offering guidance on prioritizing campaign choices to help organizations lacking the capacity to do their own research (ACE, 2023). At Charity Entrepreneurship, Sarek (2019) discusses the role of stakeholders in building a Theory of Change (ToC) to outline expected outcomes and actively involving stakeholders in creating and prioritizing research questions. She describes how the process of research engagement can be supported by gathering input from decision-makers, assessing the importance of various research questions, and selecting the most impactful ones based on these evaluations.

Beyond animal advocacy, one of the authors of this study (Chung, 2024) has conducted a multi-disciplinary review of academic literature to understand how different disciplines increase research impact and use by engaging with stakeholders. She finds that scholars identify several important stages where such engagement occurs. For example, in transdisciplinary research, across the research process, Polk (2015) describes involving stakeholders in the formulation, generation, and evaluation of knowledge, while development and education scholar, Fransman (2018), identifies five key areas where stakeholders are engaged: in knowledge production (design and implementation), research communication (representation and dissemination), research use (uptake, adaptation and utilization), research governance (agenda-setting and evaluation), and impact and learning.

In this study, we have consolidated these frameworks and perspectives into four phases for research engagement: *plan*, *produce*, *apply* and *evaluate*. We apply a more expansive framework of research engagement, rather than just focusing on translation, as it may provide a wider understanding and a broader set of opportunities to enhance the impact of research in animal advocacy.

Results

The report analyzes how animal advocates use research, starting with **use cases**—the specific scenarios in which advocates apply research, focusing on internal (organizational) and external (including movement-level) contexts. This section on use cases aims to guide advocates on the

various ways research can be beneficial in their work and to inform researchers about how their work can be valuable in practice.

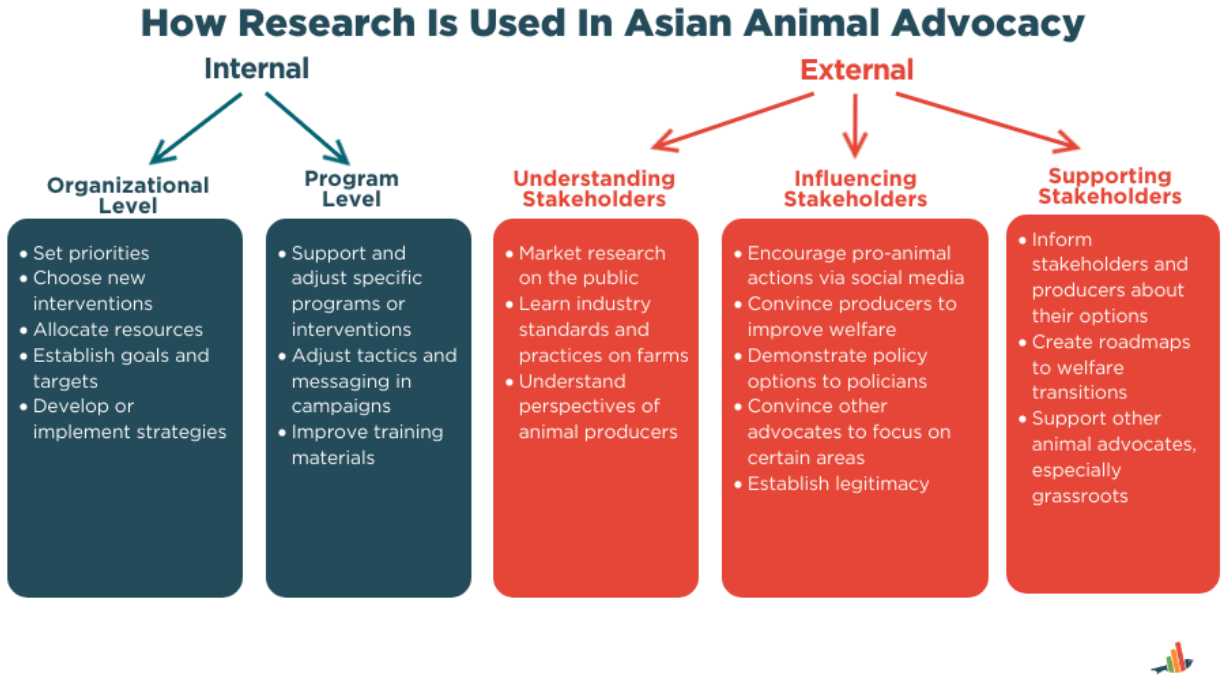
The report then examines the **barriers and enablers** of research, detailing the characteristics of research outputs that hinder effective use, and those that facilitate better use of research. This section aims to help researchers focus on generating research outputs that can be genuinely useful.

Finally, the report looks into understanding and improving the **research engagement process**, showing how advocates interact with research to highlight best practices and potential areas for improvement.

Use Cases

Animal advocates across Asia use research and data for various purposes in their work. To better understand these specific uses, we asked focus group participants an open-ended question to identify their most important use cases. We then probed for additional use cases that might have been overlooked, drawing on examples from Phase I of the research. Participants were then asked to rank these use cases, enabling us to identify the most important ones and allowing for follow-up questions to gain deeper insights into these specific applications.

Figure 1: Internal and External Uses of Research in Asian Animal Advocacy



Internal Use Cases

Aligning with findings from Phase I, our study found that research and data were often used within an advocacy organization to facilitate decision-making. We found that this occurs at the **organizational level** and the **program level**.

At the organizational level, research is used to set priorities, choose new interventions or programs, allocate resources, establish goals and targets, and develop or implement strategies. At the program level, research is used to make decisions around the design, delivery, and evaluation of individual programs or interventions. We also noted other internal applications, such as using research to improve staff training.

On the organizational level, advocates mentioned the use of research to inform future plans and establish strategic priorities. For instance, one advocate focused their strategy on building health-related campaigns and community building because of the results from a particular study:

> *Faunalytics did a study about reasons for […] going vegan or vegetarian, and the consensus from that helped to guide our work. It mentioned that focusing on health arguments and community building would be a good strategy for vegan organizations. [As] the […] only diet change organization working in the region, we felt that was very useful.*

Research was also used when considering broader advocacy approaches that an organization would focus on. One participant changed their approach from street vegan activism to corporate outreach, including developing partnerships with large corporations to improve chicken welfare, due to research into effectiveness:

> *[...] I started everything from the grassroots, and I found that not just myself, but also some other animal rights activists […] in Hong Kong, transformed to corporate outreach because we learned from some studies [that] this is a more effective way to help animals. So we transformed the way we are doing advocacy work.*

While Phase I observed that significant strategic shifts were rare, describing advocates as "tactics-flexible and cause-inflexible," this instance demonstrates how research and evidence can lead to significant shifts in advocacy approaches within animal advocacy, supporting evidence from a previous study that many advocates are interested in transitioning to different strategies or cause areas (Faunalytics, 2024). While we did not explore the reasons for greater cause-flexibility among some advocates in this study compared to Phase I, it may be related to the nascent state of the movement and smaller organization sizes in Asia—advocates in these contexts may be less tied to specific belief systems or networks. This could highlight a potentially outsized role for research in shaping the long-term strategy of organizations or movements in geographies with more nascent movements.

Research is also used in decisions regarding country-level prioritization and broader regional strategy decisions. An advocate at a large regional organization described collaborating with an internal research team to support this effort. They used a multi-stage research approach, first analyzing external reports and then collecting first-hand qualitative and survey data. This process helped them develop a tool to prioritize which of multiple Southeast Asian countries to focus on, based on scale, tractability, and global influence. As well as informing where to concentrate their effort, this research also helped in identifying which activities and approaches would be suitable in each one of these countries.

In addition to organizational-level decisions, **advocates also use research at the program-level** to support the design, development, evaluation, and adjustment of specific programs or interventions. Some organizations employ research to evaluate and modify current interventions, such as consumer surveys, to adjust tactics and messaging in diet change campaigns:

> *We do consumer surveys every two years, and they tell us what's happening, what consumer trends are, who wants to buy what, who wants to consume it, what their age groups are, and then we tailor our project that year to what we found in that research.*

Some organizations collect internal data and conduct in-house research to assess their tactics. This might be used to evaluate specific strategies or approaches—one advocate focused on community building describes using one-on-one conversations with network members and data collection from funders to assess the appropriateness of their previous recommendations and

refine them for the future. Some organizations rely on external data to analyze broader trends within a sector or part of the advocacy movement: for instance, examining the cost-effectiveness of current interventions and placing these evaluations within the broader context of the animal advocacy movement. An advocate from an organization focused on obtaining cage-free commitments from corporations noted:

> *I guess we use a lot of [publicly available] historical data […] to start plotting trend lines to see whether these cage-free commitments will be met, what the real cost-effectiveness is, if there will be any sort of backtracking of this commitment […]*

This reflects a way in which the internal application of research may vary by organization type. Larger, more established organizations have the resources to focus on research-driven strategy development, potentially at the movement level—as noted earlier, one advocate even formed a research team specifically to concentrate on strategy. These organizations may use research to evaluate a diverse range of programs and integrate findings to better allocate resources and thus boost the broader movement's effectiveness. In contrast, smaller organizations may lack even the resources to monitor their own programs. For instance, one group working on diet change mentioned:

> *We also don't have enough human resources or funding to, for example, do what Veganuary do, like calling people and getting their feedback.*

The final internal use of research—not directly related to decision-making—is the application of research in internal training, such as the creation of training materials for staff members or volunteers. One advocate noted using research to develop materials that help volunteers "distinguish between science and pseudoscience," thereby enhancing their ability to communicate in an accurate and evidence-based way. Research may also be used to generate training materials for partners within the movement or with external stakeholders, such as producers.

External Use Cases

As emphasized in Phase I of this project, research and data play a significant role when working with external stakeholders. We identified three main external uses: understanding, influencing, and supporting stakeholders. These three use cases can be interconnected and may build upon each other.

- **Understanding** involves gathering information on target stakeholders in order to identify context-appropriate solutions and inform strategies to influence them.
- **Influencing** refers to attempts to change the behavior of a stakeholder, by using research to build relationships, establish legitimacy, provide information, or build a case in order to catalyze further action.

- **Supporting** focuses on using research to inform and aid cooperative or aligned stakeholders, especially those who have already agreed to change their behavior or approaches.

In this section, we explore these various ways advocates use research with external stakeholders, starting with **understanding stakeholders**.

Advocates working with the general public via diet change advocacy often rely on consumer or market research to gain insights into consumer behavior—identifying the factors that drive them to consume certain animal products and what might persuade them to change. Many advocates emphasized the importance of understanding local consumers' needs and responses to messaging: for instance, one advocate working on vegan certification highlighted a study that led them to adjust their approach. Similarly, to better understand how broader social change, such as reduced meat consumption, is generated through the actions of advocates and the general public, advocates also discussed using social change research to explore how to trigger a major social shift with regards to animals and diet.

Advocates working with institutional stakeholders, such as corporations, conducted meetings and interviews to understand their needs before engaging. They also used external research for benchmarking or baseline studies to assess current industry standards, which helped them clarify and communicate what these stakeholders needed to achieve, and choose an appropriate approach for the current market.

> *I think the most persuasive thing we've found when talking to companies is [understanding] what the rest of the market is doing and what their competitors are doing. So, [it's useful to have] either an official benchmark or just data, like examples, case studies of what their precise competitors are doing.*

Advocates working with producers also need to understand their needs and motivations in order to generate change in practices. For instance, an organization supporting the transition to cage-free farming conducted a comprehensive needs assessment with both caged and cage-free producers to understand their challenges and perceptions regarding the transition, aiming to develop more effective strategies for moving to cage-free farming. They stressed the extent to which their work is shaped by their understanding of the needs of producers:

> *A lot of [our] work, be it producer capacity building, improving stockpersonship, or providing market-based incentive systems for farmer transition is driven by the data [on] what the farmer or the company needs, or […] [is] willing to pay.*

For advocates working with other advocates, such as movement building organizations, understanding the motivations of advocates is essential. In one case, user research, which involves gathering insights directly from individuals to understand their behaviors, needs, and motivations, was employed to explore the career paths taken by animal advocates. This helped to uncover their reasons for involvement and identify ways to better support them.

Understanding stakeholders is often a precursor to **influencing stakeholders**, which can involve either building an advocacy case, or generating legitimacy in order to better influence external stakeholders.

A key element of influencing stakeholders is building a case to persuade stakeholders—generating evidence-based arguments for stakeholders to commit to animal-friendly actions. Advocates developed arguments for use with the general public, corporate and policy stakeholders, as well as partners within the advocacy movement.

Some advocates working with the general public used research on diet interventions to better target their outreach, which may include developing more appropriate messages or integrating data into content. One advocate mentioned researching the best "call to action" for Asian consumers, while another emphasized the importance of using research to “debunk” dietary myths related to plant-based diets. Research is often tailored to specific countries or regions—for example, an organization in Indonesia has been conducting consumer research to better engage Muslim communities, while a China-based advocate, to make the case to Chinese consumers that many of them eat too much meat, generates material combining data sets on urban meat consumption, antibiotic use in livestock, and the carbon footprint of diets.

New research and data are also being used to create public-facing social media content and presentations for events. One advocate highlighted how they integrate findings to strengthen messaging aimed at encouraging flexitarians to reduce meat consumption further. Another described generating online videos and infographics from raw data to show their social media followers the number of animals affected by fur farming. Additionally, an advocate discussed using the latest research and data to craft press releases for a social media campaign in Vietnam.

Building a case for institutional stakeholders is also a very common use of research. Advocates used research outputs from multiple disciplines to convince corporate actors to switch to cage-free systems, while others used research to persuade policymakers to develop or improve their animal welfare policies. One Chinese advocate described attending a consultation before a high-level government meeting:

> *We’re fortunate enough to be able to pitch our presentations to the consultation before the Two Sessions meeting in February or March, and we use the data that we’ve found to inform those proposals and ideas for the future that the government could potentially use and take forward.*

When working with agricultural producers, research was also employed to build a case on the benefits of transitioning to higher welfare practices. To convince a farmer to improve conditions on their shrimp farm, an advocate gathered data on the optimal rearing conditions for a specific shrimp species, showing that these improvements would benefit both the producer and the animals.

Finally, some participants used research to build a case for other advocates, such as funders and partners, to persuade them to operate in new areas, collaborate, or redirect resources to alternative cause areas. One advocate uses consumer data in China to persuade other advocates to focus on certain species:

> *We also identified top species in China to work with, in the hopes that this might influence other people who also want to work in this field.*

In addition to making an advocacy case, research was seen as helping to build an organization's legitimacy with regards to stakeholders, echoing findings from Phase I of the study. Building legitimacy is particularly important for persuading stakeholders, demonstrating that the information provided is credible and that the organization is professional and capable. One advocate noted how research was instrumental in building their reputation:

> *Establishing legitimacy [is important] because we have a very strong culture of transparency and [being] evidence-based. If someone goes to our website, they will see everything about the mistakes that we've made with our approach. For example, our research specialists [identified] that some farms [have higher stocking densities than they claim] so we have that published on our website.*

When research was used to establish legitimacy, it was sometimes linked to the specific values or associations important to stakeholders. For instance, one stakeholder strategically leveraged World Bank research with policymakers in the Philippines to build credibility, recognizing the World Bank's influential role as a major funder of the country's government.

However, unlike Phase I of the study, where legitimacy was mentioned by almost all participants, building legitimacy was typically only mentioned by our participants when directly prompted. This suggests that this may not be an obvious or common use case of research in Asia. This may be due to more uncertainty about how to generate legitimacy in this context. Some advocates acknowledged not always knowing how to build legitimacy with Asian stakeholders. One advocate from a global organization starting work in Asia described the region as "a whole new territory" and that "the way we have built our legitimacy in the Americas is very different from how we're going to be doing it in Asia" and that they are "still going to need to learn a lot on that front."

On the other hand, the final use case, **supporting stakeholders**, was proactively mentioned by many participants. Research is used to inform and aid cooperative or aligned stakeholders, especially those who have already agreed to change their behavior or approaches. In these contexts, advocates are no longer trying to persuade their stakeholders but are instead working towards a shared goal together.

Once a stakeholder agrees to collaborate with the advocates, research is used to inform them about their options. For example, data on economic or welfare-related metrics might be used to inform policymakers about the economic impact of a policy decision or to create a roadmap to

help a corporate stakeholder transition to cage-free systems. One advocate uses a combination of economic analyses and data from their model farm and training centres to "*help companies who are looking to transition [figure out] what the optimal transition size is going to look like, [what] transition times [are] going to look like, what the stocking density [needs to be], or the farm size needed to be […] economically viable."*

This is also the case with producers; research allows advocates to better inform them about their options or how they can improve their bottom line while enhancing welfare outcomes. One advocate uses a research-based tool to show farmers how their mortality rate compares to other farms and suggests alternative rearing methods. Another advocate combines external research with social and economic assessments for shrimp farmers to demonstrate how their approach can contribute to "sustaining, if not adding to, their bottom lines." This approach can be applied across different stakeholders, from small-scale farmers to very large organizations:

> *We went to Thailand's second largest cage egg producer who also has a cage-free farm, and has had a major issue with feather quality and floor eggs. We use the on-farm data [to suggest] how to improve welfare conditions as well as optimize on-farm egg production, so that the cost of cage-free eggs isn't astronomically high.*

Finally, some organizations with supporting roles in the animal advocacy ecosystem use research to inform, support, and train/educate their partners. One such organization plays such a role by serving as a connector and information aggregator for their members:

> *We serve two purposes or two target audiences. One is our members where we act as their middle man to connect everyone, to collect all the data, all the information that has been discussed and put it in written documents for people to read. From that we hope that it will bolster the work that everyone does [by enabling] experience sharing from more established and multi-block organizations to smaller, grassroots level [groups].*

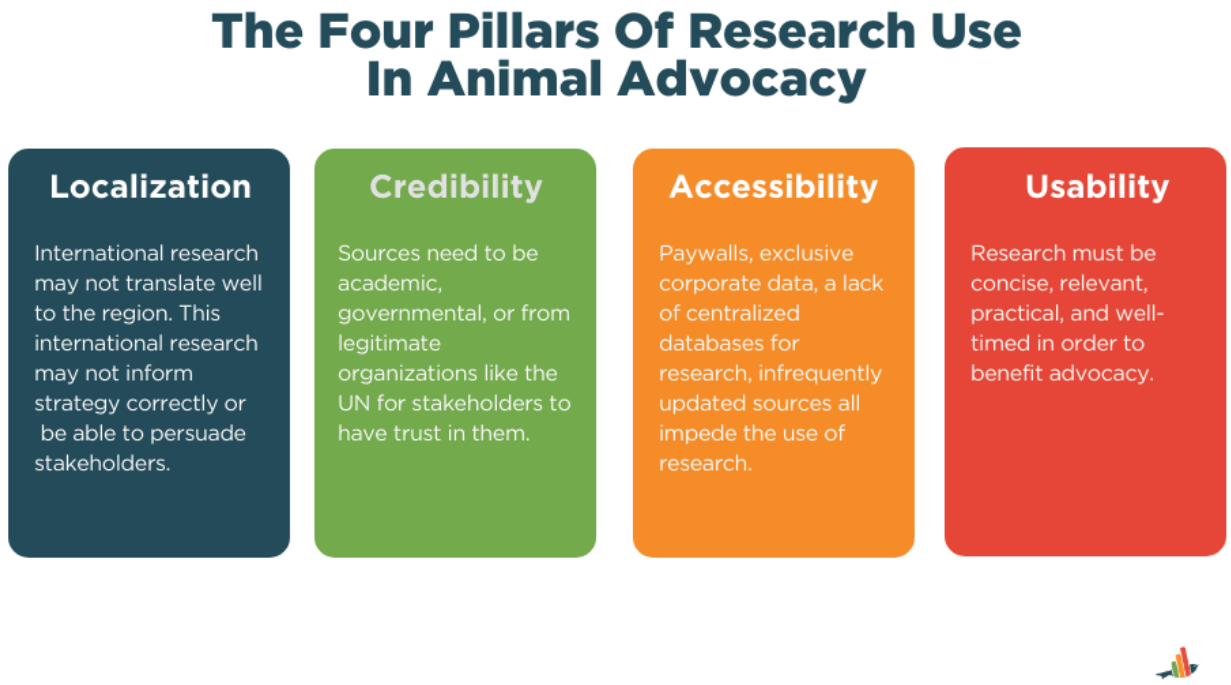
Now that we understand how and where research creates impact for animal advocates, we can explore opportunities to further increase its effectiveness. This can be approached from two perspectives: first, by enhancing the research itself—focusing on the features that either enable or obstruct its use; and second, by enhancing the research engagement process—examining how research is generated and applied. These two aspects will be explored in the following sections.

Barriers And Enablers Of Research Use

This section focuses on barriers and enablers, specifically focusing on the common features of research and data currently used, barriers that limit the effective use of research to improve advocacy outcomes, and characteristics of research that enable more effective use of research. We categorize our findings into localization, credibility, accessibility, and usability (format,

content, and timing), and discuss each category in terms of the barriers, and enablers associated with these categories.

Figure 2: The Four Pillars of Research Use In Animal Advocacy



Localization

One of the core barriers to effective research use in Asia is the **lack of localized data**. International research often doesn't translate well to local contexts, as it may lack the precise data needed to inform local strategies and can be seen by stakeholders as irrelevant. Many participants identified this shortage as a major issue, noting that it limits their ability to make evidence-based decisions and complicates efforts to persuade external stakeholders, as the research content or format may not be appropriately tailored to the local context.

The absence of localized research on topics such as dietary change and local environmental conditions was particularly damaging. For instance, the lack of consumer behavior change research hindered advocates' efforts to design effective dietary interventions in China and Indonesia. Additionally, findings can vary between local and non-localized data. In Bali, an advocate working on layer hen welfare improvements observed significant discrepancies between data collected under local conditions and the findings of an external NGO they had relied on, which limited their ability to effectively show local producers how to transition to higher welfare practices.

Non-localized research may also **fail to persuade local stakeholders**, therefore advocates emphasize the importance of localized research and data in order to better communicate with their stakeholders, and build a more effective advocacy case. Many advocates highlighted the necessity of local data on topics such as local economic conditions for effective policy and corporate advocacy. However, even for cases where local data is not strictly necessary, there may also be an issue with research perceived as non-local. Echoing a similar finding in Phase I, one advocate noted that while welfare science is not necessarily context-specific, stakeholders may just use the fact that research is not produced locally as an excuse to reject its findings:

> *I think the concept of "local studies" is valid […] But fundamental biological concepts and welfare outcomes don't change that much [across regions]. So I think pushback often is corporate or policy pushback, [when they] say, "it's not local studies," I think that's overused.*

This may indicate that perceptions of research as non-local can damage an advocacy case, regardless of the underlying reality.

Because of these concerns, a significant portion of the work associated with research use and production by advocates in Asia involves **localization of internationally-produced research**, including generating and translating content such as reports, presentations, fact sheets, and video media for local stakeholders, as well as **replicating existing research findings in a local context**. For instance, an advocate in the Philippines described encouraging local university researchers to replicate external findings on good animal husbandry practices, while another uses locally-collected demonstration farm data, presented as animated videos in local languages, to persuade local stakeholders to adopt new farming methods.

Despite the importance of local research and adaptation, it can also be challenging to produce. In Indonesia, on-farm research is hindered by communication issues, practical issues such as travel, and potential bureaucratic hurdles, such as the requirement for researchers to be accompanied by company representatives. Localization challenges may also be intensified by differences in research systems or cultures, and language barriers. International teams struggle to access local research, and local stakeholders may find it difficult to understand research published in English.

Several participants identified obtaining sufficient data as a significant challenge. This issue may be linked to the lack of localized research, as mentioned earlier, but advocates also pointed out difficulties in acquiring enough research for their specific areas of focus. One advocate highlighted the challenge of accessing data on dietary preferences, while another noted the scarcity of research and data on animal agriculture in Malaysia.

Participants also suggested encouraging, or providing targeted funding, for localized research on consumer behavior, and production practices, as well as broader regional overviews or "landscape studies" (comprehensive analyses of the current state, opportunities, challenges,

and trends regarding animal advocacy in a region). Some advocates hoped for well-known studies, such as the recent European "Smart Protein Project"—a multi-year initiative to assess new plant-based crops, develop new protein product types, explore innovative food uses, and address regulatory and commercial viability—to be replicated or expanded in Asia.

Credibility

As emphasized in Phase I of this study, one of the primary functions of research is to establish legitimacy with stakeholders. For advocates to be convinced by research and subsequently adjust their strategy, the research itself must be, or be perceived to be, credible. We define credibility as the trustworthiness and reliability of the research itself, while legitimacy refers to the broader acceptance and authority of the organization or source presenting the research in the eyes of stakeholders.

Advocates also described how providing data seen as accurate, credible and up-to-date is key to persuading institutional stakeholders and establishing legitimacy, for example, one advocate noted that accurate data "really helps with relationship building, credibility, and trust with media and partners in China."

The sources considered legitimate can vary across stakeholders. Credible sources include government data, reports from international organizations like the UNFAO or WHO, research "from an EA or an EA-aligned organization," or academic research from particular institutions.

> *Sources outside of academia need to be at least well known or accepted by the UN, I would say, for policymaking. […] Our World in Data has Oxford behind it. So I think that's more credible than other block sites or even media reports. [...] For the lay people it's good enough, but for policy makers, they do care about those things. And I believe that would be critical for […] lobbying or policy making, [or for] institutional engagements like financial institutions for banks, for proposals and all that.*

Another issue was that there may be uncertainty about which research organizations certain stakeholders consider credible. Addressing this and, if needed, informing or persuading stakeholders of a research institution's credibility could be an overlooked aspect of research engagement:

> *Of course we know GFI, [the Good Food Institute], but how much do the local authorities know about GFI? I guess the question is, although it's maybe very credible in our space, if the governments or the responsible stakeholders don't know about it, how useful would it be? So we need to pitch who GFI is […] [and understand] how we can elevate these very useful studies and data that would be acceptable by the policy makers.*

While peer-reviewed research isn't universally viewed as the "gold standard," and there are some criticisms of the process of peer-reviewed research, academic research and the processes behind it are generally regarded as credibility-enhancing.

> *There are […] academic papers that are certainly helpful for us. Even though we might only use a key takeaway from it, obviously having, the reason it has credibility is because of the whole research process.*

There may also be specific nuances in what is considered credible within a given context. One advocate highlighted that research from a major market research consulting firm, Rakuten Insights, would signal corporate interest to alternative protein investors or corporate stakeholders.

Accessibility

When relevant data exists, advocates may not be able to access it due to specific formats or sources being inaccessible, or data being fragmented and unconsolidated, making it more difficult for advocates to access.

Firstly, certain formats or sources can make it challenging for advocates to access or use research. As noted in Phase I, advocates in Asia often struggle to access academic papers due to paywalls, limiting their access to the latest findings. Accessibility issues also extend to obtaining various forms of data essential for operating in the Asian context. While trade data from international organizations and government sources were generally accessible and commonly used, advocates pointed out that certain "exclusive" corporate data sources were either unavailable or behind paywalls, further restricting access. This is a particular challenge when making a case for corporate stakeholders, when advocates only have access to a limited subset of corporate data:

> *A lot of data comes from the companies themselves. I guess the biggest bottleneck has been companies not reporting by region, and they kind of club everything into this one massive chunk of data, and you don't really have access to break them down […] [and] there isn't a centralized database that you're able to verify.*

One characteristic that affected accessibility was simply the fact that research and data was rarely seen as consolidated within a single space. Advocates described looking through various search engines, listservs, websites, and databases to find appropriate research and data, and many complained that this was both a limitation and a poor use of time:

> *Maybe it's like a fragmentation issue, I'm sure people have put together research summaries and […] pool[ed] resources together, but things are split across lots of*

> *different organizations and different journals sometimes. I do feel like I'm probably spending time compiling things that have been done before.*

Multiple advocates suggested that making data sources behind research available can ameliorate this situation, allowing advocates to use it for alternative uses. They also stressed the value of consolidating data, with some suggesting larger organizations in the movement hosting a range of data sources or research briefs for Asia:

> *Having [a secure repository of] research briefs, that the movement could contribute to and we can adapt and modify, could be really useful, [and] I think that would save a lot of time actually within the movement. I don't think there's anything like that, and I don't know if there's something similar in other movements.*

There are also other specific characteristics that make research usable, such as comprehensiveness—one advocate noted that EU reviews on welfare are a “one-stop-shop” where you can find a comprehensive review of all research in the field, with “concise conclusions for how species should be raised in different farming systems.”

Another challenge to data access is obtaining accurate data—research and data needs to be accurate or perceived as accurate, in order to support precise, evidence-based decision-making and build legitimacy with stakeholders. Several advocates emphasized the importance of data accuracy in their work. For those working closely with animals and producers, accurate data is essential for making informed decisions that enhance farm animal welfare.

However, obtaining accurate data remains a significant challenge. One advocate noted that while government and trade data are typically reliable when first produced, they often become outdated—for instance, FAO data is generally accurate but not updated frequently enough. Data provided directly by institutional stakeholders can also be unreliable; one advocate highlighted difficulties in verifying whether cage-free pledges have been met, as companies sometimes deliberately obscure or inflate their commitments. They noted: “generally companies report what they want to report and how they want to report.”

Some important enablers for improving access to accurate data include "knowing the sources," building institutional knowledge, and consolidating sources. Additionally, repeated data collection from the same source, or repeating or updating studies at regular intervals, were ways of ensuring that advocates had access to accurate data.

Usability: Format, Content, and Timing

Many advocates mentioned that the format, content, and timing of research affected its **usability**. The format in which research was consumed or communicated was often mentioned. Peer-reviewed articles are seen as credible, but not necessarily usable or accessible, therefore

advocates opt for concise and less academic formats to make research a lot more usable by many external stakeholders. Usability barriers may vary by stakeholder. For instance, an advocate observed that agricultural producers often struggle with academic research, so they create video and audiovisual content to aid the producers' understanding. In contrast, corporate and policy stakeholders are more likely to be limited by time constraints rather than comprehension issues. This means that communicating research in a concise and easily consumed format, like a research brief or one-pager, is more practical. One advocate noted that:

> *If we're preparing a research brief for [corporations], then we want something concise [and] visually relevant. So then we'd look at more infographics or we have to create […] summaries and so forth.*

Websites and blogs are commonly used for research communication—advocates mentioned both finding research and data on these platforms and publishing their own data. Social media posts can also be used to share research and data, especially for public-facing advocacy efforts, with the added benefit of generating engagement metrics that can help refine strategies and improve dissemination efforts.

The **content** of research is also a key consideration in achieving its use cases. To be effective, the content of research must be both relevant and practical—similar to Phase I of this study, welfare science, environmental studies, and public health research were among the most commonly used types, as they are essential for building strong advocacy cases. Additionally, content should be concise and contain actionable recommendations, in order to be easier to apply and communicate.

As well as preferring relevant and usable content, advocates also naturally favored data or information that supports pro-animal or pro-vegan outcomes. As one advocate noted, "we're advocacy organizations, so we're going to also use information that's going to support our case." Research is often more beneficial when it emphasizes "positive" findings, such as how meat reduction or improved welfare can be mutually beneficial for various stakeholders, rather than focusing on the negative aspects of animal farming. This opportunity-focused approach may be more effective when engaging institutional stakeholders, such as producers or policymakers.

Finally, **timing** is also crucial—research that isn't "in sync" with an organization's work, due to delays in publication or conversion to more suitable formats, may arrive too late or in a form that isn't actionable.

> *Usually, when our research is launched or the results are shared, it might be related to something that we're not currently working on, [or something] that we might work on in two months. […] I think the biggest challenge is not being synced in the same needs and*

> *with the [level] of details and tailoring that's necessary to really make effective use of data.*

Several advocates noted that research driven by academic curiosity or interests rather than a practical application, which lacks direct relevance to advocates or is often delayed by slow academic timelines, is rarely the most useful for achieving advocacy goals.

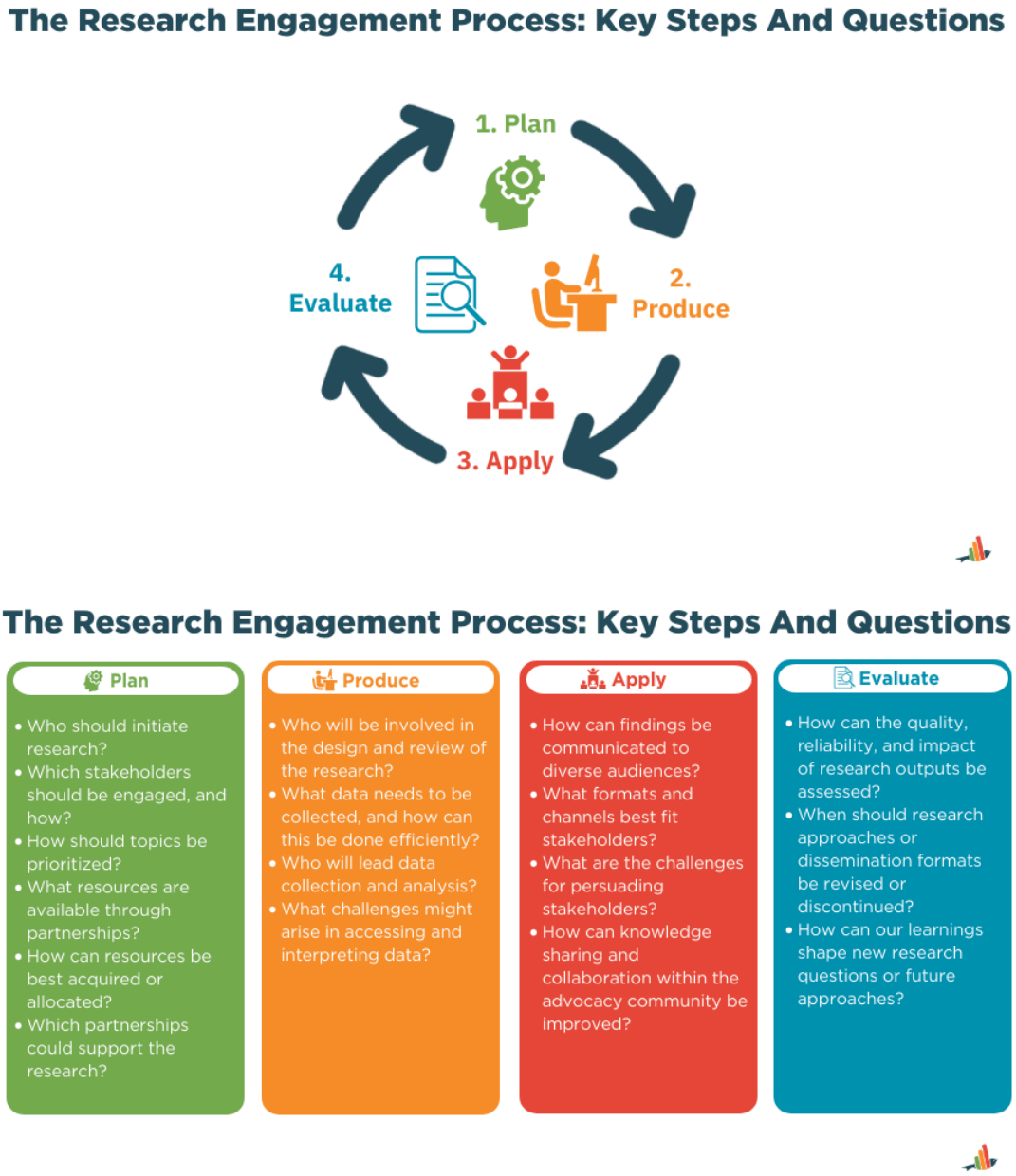
Increasing Impact Through The Research Engagement Process

We have now provided a framework for thinking about the main ways advocates use research and identified factors that can act as barriers or enablers to its use. Through this, we've observed that advocates in Asia rarely engage with research solely as users or consumers. Not only do they invest significantly in the translation and localization of research (echoing findings from Phase I), they also conducted their own research and collected their own data. In fact, almost all of the participants in our study were involved in the *production* of research. This may be related to the lack of local research and data on Asian countries—advocates feel they need to conduct their own research in order to address the context-specific questions needed to inform their work.

In this section, we take a holistic look at how research is conducted, adapted, and communicated by Asian advocates, identifying current limitations as well as opportunities for increasing research impact. We will examine the entire "research engagement" process, from planning, production, application, to evaluation; the role of advocates, researchers, and external stakeholders at each stage; and how this process may vary across different use cases. In particular, we highlight key considerations for research producers (which can include researchers and advocates) at each stage of the process, which can provide a framework that can inform and improve future research projects.

Please note that this is a description of how we observed the research engagement process and a framework for how to think about engagement during this process, not a comprehensive guide on how to conduct research.

Figure 3: Key Steps And Questions Involved In The Research Engagement Process



Note that, while this framework is visualized as a cyclical diagram, the process of research engagement can vary across use cases and organizations. The order of steps can vary, not all participants followed all steps, and research engagement may follow a cyclical or repeating process.

Stage 1 — Plan: Deciding To Use Or Conduct Research, Acquiring Resources, And Beginning Engagement

The first step of the process we observed was the decision to initiate research, which can be led by an advocacy organization, a researcher, or a funder. An advocate may recognize that they lack the relevant information to pursue their goals—such as selecting or enhancing a program, or persuading external stakeholders. The decision could also be influenced by suggestions from funders; one Indonesian advocate's funder recommended that they first produce a scoping report on the current implementation of animal welfare standards before launching a campaign to improve adherence to these standards.

The decision-making process may also involve additional stakeholders. Some organizations have procedures where research partners can apply to conduct research together, or where advocates are actively involved in applying for research funding. For larger projects, a research team composed of internal and/or external researchers might also be formed at this stage.

Another key step that informed research decisions was **stakeholder engagement**. For example, advocates conducting on-the-ground studies to improve farming systems worked with local farmers during the planning process to better understand and align the research with their interests. Many participants also emphasized the value of collaborating with partners and stakeholders to enhance the quality of the research, streamline the research process, and ensure that the research outputs fit with the intended use case. Engagement typically continues throughout the research process, helping to build relationships that play a role in later stages.

> *Before we start the study, we also engage the local chief executive or the city mayor, since the study will also benefit the community. So we start engaging with them, and the mayor will help us connect with the farmers. It's really important that we involve the government if you really want good data.*

It is important to note that stakeholder engagement can be quite time-consuming, and involve complex local networks that are difficult to navigate. This could require, for example, multiple stakeholder meetings before research can commence.

Indeed, a key consideration when planning to do research is acquiring and allocating the required resources—both in terms of **funding and human resources**. This can look quite different depending on the size of the organization.

For smaller organizations, this process typically involves applying for external funding on an ad-hoc basis, or relying on limited internal resources for data and research tasks. Larger organizations may have dedicated research resources, along with specialized departments that manage these budgets, review internal research proposals and allocate staff time. One

advocate, who was focused on creating an evidence-based Asia-focused strategy and theory of change for a large advocacy organization, actively assembled a team that leverages research to evaluate the potential impact of various broad strategic approaches.

For most advocacy organizations, human resources and funding are both crucial factors that can either restrict or facilitate research. One frequent challenge mentioned by advocates was the time required to conduct research and collect data, described by one as the “resource that’s hardest to come by.” This has led some advocacy organizations to forgo research altogether. For instance, one advocate expressed a desire to conduct hands-on research with farmers to validate and build upon government data but ultimately decided to “[rely] on government data because doing a survey really can be expensive, and [takes a lot of] time.”

It is also difficult for advocates to find external researchers with relevant expertise. For example, one advocate highlighted the difficulty in finding local researchers who understood the specific welfare standards the organization aimed to implement. Nonetheless, several advocates working at smaller organizations seem to be able to tap into university resources, working with affiliated researchers who brought specific expertise, local knowledge, and connections to their projects.

Unsurprisingly, many advocates described funding as a barrier, noting that it often constrained the types of research they could undertake. One advocate mentioned that while they could conduct localized surveys, they lacked the resources to perform "credible academic research for local purposes" and would need to apply for additional funding to do so.

Advocates proposed several ideas to improve the planning phase. On resourcing, some advocates suggested that creating more **dedicated research funding** within the movement would benefit organizations with constrained resources, allowing them to avoid having to choose between research and action. Advocates highlighted the positive impact of two donor organizations that provided specific resources for research, believing that dedicated funding has led to “a growth in overall research" in the region.

Strengthening **partnerships** between multiple organizations was also recommended as a way to improve this stage of the process. One advocate mentioned forming several partnerships across different countries that have been particularly valuable, providing resources to use at later stages:

> *We use partnerships to improve our research. For example, we partner with a college or university in India. They offered to give us a few acres of land to build ponds, which were then used for research with fish welfare improvement. We are also partnering with other cooperatives that will help us. We are finding out if we can build a lab with them to help us reach more farmers and do more of these water quality measurements.*

Partnerships can also enhance high-level research planning at the movement level—an advocate from a larger organization mentioned outsourcing parts of their research process to better allocate human resources within the advocacy movement, allowing specialized research organizations to handle specific research projects.

Based on our discussions with advocates, we developed these key questions that advocates and researchers should consider during the planning stage:

- Who should initiate the research?
- Which stakeholders should be engaged, and how might they be involved?
- How should research topics or projects be prioritized?
- What resources do we have available? What are other resources we could tap into, e.g. via partnerships?
- What is the best way to acquire or allocate resources?
- Which partnerships could be formed to support the research?

Stage 2 — Produce: Research Design, Data Collection & Analysis, Write-up, And Review

Once decisions have been made about the research topic, resourcing, and key stakeholders, the next stage we observed was producing the research. This phase typically begins with designing the research approach and defining study objectives, followed by data collection and analysis, and generally concludes with write-up and review. Examples of the kind of research and data produced by participants in this study involve collecting producer data on transitioning to cage-free farms, obtaining government data to support welfare interventions, and using survey and market data on fur use to develop an educational campaign.

The production phase usually begins with **research design**, where research questions are established, and goals of the research clarified and communicated to the team or organization. Some advocates held meetings with local or external researchers to facilitate this process, while others used standardized templates or structures. One larger organization working on regional advocacy, for example, had created project proposal templates to guide the development of research questions.

Once the research design is set, advocates usually move onto **data collection and analysis**. While this process is typically led by advocates or researchers, some advocates may bring in external staff during the analysis phase to gain fresh perspectives. For example, one advocate "assign[ed] staff members within [their] Coalition with the capacity to analyze the data," while another involved four researchers from different disciplines to analyze farm data. Involving multiple researchers may bring value addressing complex, interdisciplinary issues, such as those that lie at the crossroads of economics, law, and welfare science.

Advocates highlighted challenges in data collection, emphasizing that data accessibility is often hindered by fragmentation and consolidation issues, and that access can be obstructed either deliberately or due to local logistical problems (see the above "Accessibility" section for details). Gathering data from producers can be particularly challenging—advocates noted that producers in lower-income Asian countries can be difficult to track and access, complicating the data collection process.

> *It's easier to track corporations, but it's very hard to track producers because most producers in Indonesia keep their location hidden.*

There may also be issues related to **data quality.** One advocate conducting an analysis of the dietary impacts of meat consumption in their region observed that survey and self-reported data was often low-quality. Another advocate conducting a scoping study on antimicrobial resistance in eggs noted that some of the research they relied on was based on a very small sample size (only 10 eggs were tested in the entire sample), rendering it completely unreliable.

Some of the challenges of data collection could be addressed with technology. For example, technology could be used to automate resource-intensive data management tasks—one advocate suggested integrating AI into analytics, while another emphasized how AI advancements could enable more consistent data sourcing and updates. The concept of an independent data monitoring system was also proposed as a solution to reduce the resources spent on data acquisition:

> *[It] would be really nice to have [an independent system that kind of sits and provides the data] on [topics like] on-farm disease monitoring, disease reporting, welfare reporting. That would be really helpful, and that's a [data] vacuum that we are battling all the time.*

Data consolidation also emerged as a key area for improvement. Some of the more established organizations noted that their work was facilitated by maintaining extensive internal databases or research repositories. These data sources are sometimes shared between organizations on an ad-hoc basis, but are rarely openly available to other advocates across the movement. Some advocates suggested improving access to data by consolidating data into a regional database. They observed that it is already possible to leverage limited data sources collected by local grassroots groups for national or regional campaigns—a process that could be extended and formalized:

> *We're working with local groups […] who have databases in their own country. They have the expertise, and they understand the issues and who are the key players.*

Moving into **data analysis**, some advocates expressed uncertainties about interpreting imperfect or incomplete data to make decisions on animal production, alternative proteins, animal welfare, and meat consumption in the evolving Asian context. For example, one

advocate cited the challenge of identifying causality and counterfactuals when designing research to evaluate their organization's impact:

> *One of the issues that we do find […] is that it's really hard for us to run counterfactuals. […] We've used gestation crate commitments as a counterfactual. [...] In most parts of Asia these commitments were not met at all. In fact, in many other parts of the world these commitments were not met with any sort of implementation work to fulfill the commitment. So we use that as a counterfactual. But I think that's not necessarily the most accurate counterfactual, but then there is really no way for us to know [until] we reach [the final point of the commitments].*

In addressing challenges related to data analysis and interpretation, one advocate mentioned using modeling and predictions. They found that agricultural forecasts, like those from the USDA Foreign Agricultural Service, to be a useful tool for making estimates about agricultural trends and suggested that better use of predictions or modeling across different areas could help advocates better understand and communicate uncertainties.

Finally, the research production phase generally ends with **report write-up and review**. The **write-up** might involve advocates or the researchers, and can be in various different formats. Research **review** can occur at different stages—during the initial draft, while preparing for publication, or through cross-checking after publication—and can involve both internal and external stakeholders.

> *We shortlist the most important stakeholders that need to read the draft. Usually a maximum of 20 people need to read the first draft, and then after their feedback, we polish the research and then have it approved by the university head and our executive director.*

One advocate emphasized the importance of using their network, involving other members of the animal advocacy community, to review write-ups or internal documents. Advocates working on institutional advocacy engaged with policy or corporate stakeholders to observe and review data and research, allowing for the integration of feedback, as well as signaling transparency and honesty. Both examples demonstrate the value of engaging stakeholders in the review process to share knowledge, build trust and enhance research quality.

During the production stage, advocates and researchers should consider these key questions:

- Who will be involved in the design and review of this research?
- What data needs to be collected, and how could this be done most efficiently? Are there existing databases (public or private) that we could use?
- Who will lead the data collection and analysis, and how can external stakeholders contribute?

- What challenges might arise in accessing and interpreting data, and how can they be addressed?
- What technologies could assist the data collection and analysis process?

Stage 3 — Apply: Share, Adapt, And Integrate

After analysis, research and data must be communicated and integrated into the organization's advocacy work, which involves adapting the findings into formats usable by advocates or stakeholders and integrating them across specific use cases.

Research is shared in different ways depending on use case. For internal purposes, research is often shared through team discussions, internal reports or presentations. For external uses, such as persuading or informing stakeholders, findings may need to be adapted into diverse, more accessible formats tailored to corporate, policy, or producer stakeholders. Adapted outputs are then either stored, used internally, or distributed through various channels: some are stored in internal databases, integrated into tools, or shared via academic outlets, including open-source platforms.

In external use cases, **sharing research** was a key step. Once research was completed, seminars and presentations were organized to share findings with specific audiences, such as mayors and farmers. Some advocates engaged the media for broader public dissemination, while others shared research with larger advocacy organizations to discuss the relevance and strategies of the research. Recognizing the importance of sharing research with different stakeholders, some larger organizations have dedicated communication teams to manage the dissemination of findings to the general public or other advocacy groups.

While sharing research findings across the movement was generally seen as a positive trend, one advocate also observed that smaller organizations might be more hesitant to share their findings with international advocates. Fostering a more supportive environment for such sharing would not only increase the visibility of research but also enable larger organizations or funders to gain valuable insights into regional, on-the-ground contexts, thereby facilitating more effective strategy adjustments and resource allocation.

> *We should start sharing our research in the movement, because we share it outside the movement, but we don't share it in FAST, probably because we felt too shy [and have] some imposter syndrome. Being in Asia, from a marginalized country […] [we] should share more.*

As mentioned in the *Localization* section, **adapting research** for dissemination to stakeholders was crucial. As well as converting to context-suitable formats, advocates also stressed the importance of "finding the hooks" in their research to match stakeholders' interests, and

adapting findings for this purpose. For example, advocates had to identify the interests of policy stakeholders, so that they could tailor their research outputs to highlight those aspects.

To improve accessibility, researchers could consider proactively translating research into local Asian languages. Furthermore, recognizing that some advocates or stakeholders might be competent but non-native English speakers, providing alternative formats can be beneficial. As one advocate noted:

> *You have to make it easy to read. I remember there is a function from the 80,000 hours […] website. They don't just have a published article, but they also have audio and transcript you can select at the same time. That helped me much faster to read through everything.*

Finally, **integrating research** into practical advocacy work is a key step; variations of this have been discussed extensively in the *Use Cases* section.

One challenge in the integration phase is receiving pushback from external stakeholders. For example, advocates noted that corporate or policy stakeholders are often resistant to change and that, despite presenting evidence-based arguments, many stakeholders may still not prioritize welfare considerations:

> *I've thought a lot about consumer research and [I've been] using it more, but in my experience I'm not finding that it shifts corporates [that much]. […] The challenge is more to get them to value the concept.*

Engaging stakeholders in the planning or design phase of a research project may help to mitigate these challenges—for example, engaging with the target audience, researching their preferences, or consulting with advocates who work with similar stakeholders could allow advocates to better target research efforts. In the case of corporate or policy pushback, advocates described finding areas other than welfare where corporate or government interests can align with welfare concerns, such as environment or health.

During the application stage, advocates and researchers should consider these key questions:

- How should research findings be communicated to ensure clarity and accessibility for different audiences?
- What formats and channels will best suit the intended stakeholders, and how can the findings be adapted accordingly?
- What challenges might arise in persuading stakeholders, and how can these be mitigated?

- How can knowledge sharing and collaboration within the advocacy community be enhanced to improve the use and dissemination of research?

Stage 4 — Evaluate: Review And Learning

Research and data are typically evaluated post-completion to determine future actions, such as additional research or expanded implementation. This often involved looking at whether results addressed their initial questions and requirements. To do this, some advocates mentioned conducting post-publication assessments to gauge impact and reflect on the process. Larger organizations might conduct whole-team reviews to assess the overall success of research projects:

> *"If [a research] project goes on for a year, there is a quarterly review […] of how it is doing and everyone will criticize, or offer feedback to the research. And if it has to be shut down, there would be that decision to make."*

In some cases, research projects are shut down if outcomes or data seem less valuable.

> *Regarding if you're not getting the results right, you need to stop of course, and assess what's going on? We had that experience where we were not getting the results that we wanted, and the results […] were more or less parallel to [welfare] standards we were following, so we stopped.*

Others decided to discontinue aspects of their research portfolios, including certain types of research (e.g. qualitative studies) or dissemination formats (e.g. academic papers), due to limited effectiveness or uptake.

The evaluation stage can be closely tied to the planning stage, creating a cyclical and ongoing process, as it informs future research questions, and new processes. Evaluation may also generate insights that inspire other organizations to begin, replicate or expand their research, creating ripple effects on the research strategies and agendas of organizations across the movement. This highlights and expands the value of knowledge sharing, beyond research findings but also learnings and reflections on the research process.

During the evaluation stage, advocates and researchers should consider these key questions:

- How can the quality, reliability, and impact of research outputs be assessed?
- When should certain research approaches or dissemination formats be discontinued or revised?

- How might our learnings inform new research questions or future approaches to research?

Conclusions

This study highlights both the shared challenges and unique opportunities faced by animal advocates in Asia. While many findings resonate with global trends from Phase I—such as the importance of research in influencing stakeholders and guiding internal decisions, and the need for sharing and adapting research findings—Asian advocates also encounter distinct barriers. Alongside the core issue of the scarcity of localized research, we also identified difficulties in translation and adaptation, specific hurdles in tracking and collaborating with producers, a lack of data consolidation, and the unique challenges posed by non-democratic governments, diverse cultural and religious contexts, and significant socio-economic disparities in the region. This may indeed reflect a challenge faced by advocates operating in many geographies where the movement is nascent—in these contexts there may be only a limited body of local research, and advocates are driven to fill in knowledge gaps themselves. Yet organizations in nascent movements tend to be smaller with fewer resources, forcing advocates to juggle multiple roles, and blurring the lines between advocacy and research.

From Knowledge Translation To Research Engagement

Interestingly, this has led to a more complex relationship between Asian advocates and research, where advocates and even external stakeholders are engaged across different stages of the research process. This challenges the more traditional view of research as a contained and linear process, first conducted by researchers and then handed over for utilization by end users (e.g. advocates). In fact, the intermingling of researchers, advocates and external stakeholders across the research process may offer a more impactful model for research in advocacy, providing multiple opportunities for the ultimate users of the research to shape its direction, interpret results (integrating their knowledge of operating contexts) and adapt findings to most effectively communicate and drive change in their local contexts.

Thus, this report has presented the Research Engagement process to expand our focus beyond simply translating research to actively involving stakeholders in the formulation, production, communication, application and evaluation of research. In particular, we have endeavored to key considerations and potential best practices across each stage to provide a guiding tool for advocates and researchers looking to increase the impact of their research efforts.

Building Culture And Infrastructure For Knowledge Sharing

That said, a central theme from this study (and Phase I) is the need to foster greater sharing of research and knowledge, both across the international community and among regional peers. Our findings indicate that both research infrastructure and culture need to be considered here.

Improving the infrastructure for knowledge sharing through shared resource databases, Asia-focused advocacy events, and joint research agendas will encourage more effective collaboration. Another important consideration is the use of data consolidation platforms and tools to support advocates. While many organizations use internal databases, few have expanded these to a regional level—a gap that could potentially be filled by community-building organizations in the region. The value of research could also be expanded through the development of reusable tools that aid in decision-making or support external research use cases.

The other half of the knowledge-sharing equation is culture—while Phase I noted recent improvements in the culture of sharing in global animal advocacy, some Asian advocates expressed reluctance to share research findings with the international community. Investigating ways to foster a more supportive environment for sharing research and data within the movement, particularly for research generated by smaller organizations in the Global South, could be a valuable area for further exploration.

Optimising Resources Through Local And International Coordination

In the short term, greater support, acknowledgment and sharing of local research findings is essential—empowering or funding advocates to conduct local research in some high-impact areas may also significantly enhance their ability to quickly address pressing local issues. Addressing short-term research shortages could benefit from improved coordination and creative strategies to answer questions for multiple organizations simultaneously. One approach could be to co-prioritize a research agenda between local advocates, researchers, funders and local stakeholders. This would involve collaboratively planning and developing open-access research in accessible formats, focusing on shared goals or identified data gaps, and identifying projects that address common questions across organizations.

Looking to the mid- to long-term, the international animal advocacy community can consider redirecting research resources to neglected regions, particularly parts of Asia with high concentrations of factory-farmed animals and potential for change. Some of the cases we highlighted, where an advocate shifted their focus from street outreach to corporate advocacy based on research findings, and where a large organization focused their operations on specific

Southeast Asian countries after developing a research-based prioritization tool, indicate how marginal improvements in research in these areas could significantly influence the direction of organizations in nascent movements.

Scaling Research Capacity In Emerging Advocacy Landscapes

As well as redirecting the efforts of targeted research organizations, and increasing research funding, this shift of resources to Asia could be accomplished by strengthening international university partnerships, and fostering local researchers' interest in these fields. It is critical to note that developing local research capacity is crucial. As we saw from this study, producing research for Asian stakeholders often requires a deep understanding of local norms, attitudes, and on-the-ground advocacy, which international researchers may lack. In fact, one experienced international advocate who moved to Asia noted that, only after conducting a field visit in Indonesia did he recognize the scope, and limitations, of what was possible in that context. This highlights the difficulty of understanding key strategic issues without firsthand knowledge of the local context.

Advocate-researchers bring immense value to the field through their deep understanding of local contexts and stakeholder networks. However, as they engage in research, we must acknowledge the trade-off with time spent on direct advocacy actions. As the movement grows and specializes, it's likely that we'll see a greater division of labor between researchers and advocates. The key question becomes: How can we preserve the unique insights and local knowledge that advocate-researchers provide while scaling and specializing our efforts?

We believe the research engagement model, a more inclusive approach to research, offers a promising solution. By integrating different stakeholders across the research process to align interests and capture contextual knowledge. This approach can help maintain the valuable perspective of advocate-researchers while allowing for increased efficiency and specialization. This isn't a rigid model, but rather a flexible way of working that we'll need to adapt and refine as we go. This brings us back to the critical importance of knowledge sharing within the movement. By openly sharing our experiences, successes, and failures of conducting research in emerging advocacy landscapes, we can collectively learn and continuously improve our efforts and impact for animals.

Caveats & Limitations

As with all reports, this one has some important caveats and limitations to bear in mind.

- **Language:** Our focus groups were conducted in English, with an option for Chinese, which was not used—this may have neglected local advocates who did not feel comfortable participating in an English-language focus group.
- **Local Contacts:** We relied on an existing network to recruit participants, which may have led to an underrepresentation of grassroots organizations. Additionally, some participants had pre-existing relationships with some of the researchers conducting the study, which could have influenced their responses.
- **Limited Sample:** As with any qualitative research, our study included a smaller sample size (n = 16), and the views expressed by participants may not fully represent the perspectives of all advocates in the region. Standard limitations of qualitative research apply, meaning the findings should be interpreted as reflective of the sample rather than the entire advocacy community.

Supplementary Materials

Detailed Method

This section provides additional detail about the methods described in the body of this report.

Ethics Review & Preregistration

This study has been approved by the University of Sydney ethics board (Reference Number: 2024/HE000286), therefore multiple ethical considerations related to conflicts of interest, protection of participant information and possible risks have been considered.

Sample Frame

The full population for this study comprised approximately 60 animal advocacy organizations, identified and maintained by Faunalytics and Good Growth for previous research and ongoing communications. This list served as the basis for our stratified sampling approach. Organizations were selected based on two key criteria: the primary stakeholders they engage with and the countries in which they operate.

Major stakeholders associated with each organization were determined using existing knowledge of their activities, supplemented by a brief review of their descriptions if any uncertainties arose. The study aimed to conduct at least 15 interviews, covering over 20% of the identified organizations. In qualitative research, saturation typically occurs after 10-12 interviews in a focused population. Since the primary sampling frame was based on target stakeholders and countries of operation, our goal was to include two respondents representing each relevant stakeholder type. Given that many organizations work with multiple stakeholders across various countries, this target was achievable with 16 interviews.

Data Collection

Data was collected through virtual interviews with representatives from the selected organizations. The initial outreach was conducted via a recruitment email, which was drafted and reviewed by the University of Sydney's ethics board. For medium and large organizations, the primary contact was typically a senior leader responsible for research, strategy, or engagement. In the case of smaller organizations, the founder or executive director was usually the point of contact. Contact details were obtained from the existing database.

Focus group discussions were held virtually using Zoom between May and June 2024, with each session lasting approximately 75-90 minutes. Participants were required to provide written consent before joining the study and were asked for their permission to record the discussions. The sessions were recorded, and the audio was transcribed through a secure third-party platform. These transcripts were then anonymized and uploaded securely.

All aspects of data collection, management, and reporting were carefully designed to protect the confidentiality and anonymity of both the individuals and the organizations involved. The consent form explicitly informed participants that no one outside the research team would have access to any raw or identifiable data.

Data Analysis

Interview transcriptions and notes were analyzed using an iterative, inductive thematic coding approach. Each research question was addressed with a specific set of codes, which were applied using the qualitative coding platform Dovetail. Jack Stennett conducted the initial coding, with Jah Ying Chung reviewing all codes to ensure consistency.

The analysis was carried out collaboratively by Jack Stennett and Jah Ying Chung on an online whiteboard platform (Miro), following the knowledge framework outlined in the Results section. This involved exporting all codes from Dovetail to Miro, where they were combined with insights from the transcripts to identify emerging patterns, themes, and categories. The codes were then organized and refined to effectively address the research questions posed in the study.